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# Does Servant Leadership Style Induce Positive Organisational Behaviors? A Conceptual Study of Servant Leadership, Psychological Capital, and Intention to Quit Relationship

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## Abstract

This study examined the impact of servant leadership, an employee and community focused leadership style on followers' attitude and behaviour. Specifically, in this paper, we examine how servant leadership and psychological capital may enlighten our understanding of psychological mechanisms that affect follower behaviours. Servant leadership style as penned by Robert Greenleaf that servant leaders guide followers to adopt the behaviour of their leaders by putting others needs above their own. Psychological Capital, a form of positive organisational behaviour, gained much importance in recent years because of its usefulness in producing beneficial results for employees and the whole organisation. From emerging research on servant leadership and based on social exchange theory (SET), we proposed a model contending that servant leaders increase employees' PsyCap which directly influences Employees' intention to quit. As proposed, servant leadership will be negatively related to employees' intention to quit and positively related to PsyCap. PsyCap will mediate the relationship between servant leadership and intention to quit.

**Keywords:** Servant Leadership, Follower, Employees, Model PsyCap, Intention

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# Introduction

This study drawing from social exchange theory proposes how servant leadership and certain aspects of positive organisational behaviour may affect follower's behaviour and outcomes. In this study, we extended our work on turnover research (e.g.Hom et al., 2017; Kashyap & Rangnekar, 2016; Rodriguez, 2016) to precisely study how theoretical and conceptual advances in servant leadership theory and PsyCap can edify our understanding of possible mechanisms that affect intention to quit.

Robert Greenleaf in 1977 in his seminal work on the servant leadership, propagated servant leadership theory, as a leadership style which focuses on serving first, which means their primary emphasis is to serve and serve first. As Greenleaf describes it in his book of 2002 edition, "Servant Leadership, the style": … "begins with the natural feeling that one wants to serve, to serve first. The conscious choice brings one to aspire to lead. That person is sharply different from one who is a leader first, perhaps because of the need to assuage an unusual power drive or to acquire material possessions". (p. 27)

Several studies have been conducted to investigate the impact servant leadership have on organisational outcomes in work-related settings (Russell & Stone, 2002; Shaw & Newton, 2014; Spears, 2004). Findings demonstrate a substantial positive influence of leaders who go through servant leadership on positive organisational climate and employees' trust in leadership ( Joseph & Winston, 2005; Black, 2010).

The extent review of the literature justifies for more research on servant leadership for two reasons: Firstly, the earlier literature on leadership styles that have received more attention in the occupational settings consists of other leadership styles, i.e. transformational leadership, transactional leadership, charismatic leadership and so on. Also, truly little is known about servant leadership in work-related settings. Consequently, little evidence has been found about the psychological mechanism by which servant leadership influences the organisational outcomes. Secondly, the most recently published meta-analytic study by Hoch, Bommer, Dulebohn, and Wu, (2016) showed that servant leadership explained more variance in job attitudes and behaviours than other leadership types. Therefore, Hoch et al., (2016) emphasised the need for more research on servant leadership "as a stand-alone leadership approach that is capable of helping leadership researchers and practitioners better explain a broad range of outcomes" (p. 2).

In continuation of the discussion above, this study proposes twofold contributions to advances and conceptualises servant leadership and PsyCap literature. Despite of the early empirical evidence of the usefulness of servant leadership in explaining follower outcomes (Barbuto & Wheeler, 2006; Drury, 2004; Gregory Stone, Russell, & Patterson, 2004), a very few studies have tried to investigate the impact of servant leadership on employee intention to quit (Chiniara & Bentein, 2016; Hoch et al., 2016). Therefore, this study the researchers proposed that the leaders' servant leadership has an impact on employees' intention to quit.

Moreover, beside argument developed above, in a handful of studies on servant leadership and employees' intention to quit, the majority of the studies have mainly captivated on the direct effect of servant leadership on employees' intention to quit only, and "little is known empirically about the underlying psychological processes that are activated to enhance individual performance at work" (Chiniara & Bentein, 2016, p. 1). In a conceptual paper on servant leadership, Brohi, Hamzah, Khuhro, Akhtar, and Qureshi, (2018) argued that servant leadership standalone is not enough to influence organisational outcomes; they proposed to investigate the mechanism through which servant leadership has a significant impact on follower outcomes. To further the scholarship on servant

leadership and underlying mechanisms through which the influence of servant leadership can be translated into beneficial organisational outcomes, further investigation of such underlying psychological processes is necessary to understand. To address this research gap, the authors incorporated social exchange theory (Emerson, John, Harold, & Blau, 1976) and proposed that PsyCap as the mediator of this relationship. This study argues that supervisors' servant leadership first develops four components of PsyCap of employees', which in turn negatively influences their intention to quit.

Thus, the indirect effect of PsyCap between servant leadership and intention to quit relationship, the current study proposes that this study will help to broaden the horizon of the existing servant leadership and PsyCap literature and gives future directions to fill the gap in the literature.

## Servant Leadership

Since the early start of servant leadership theory, various researchers have tried to give a more precise definition of servant leadership and produced traits/ characteristics leaders should have. In this regard, Mahembe and Engelbrecht, (2014), Lindahl, (2010) and Whitaker, (2009) provided the concept of servant leadership by propagating several characteristics of effective leadership.

Four decades ago, Robert K. Greenleaf penned his work which was titled as "Servant Leadership". In that, he termed that "a man's journey and his realisation are the truest forms of leadership in which the leader has the utmost aspiration to serve others and help them to reach their true potential". Organizations following this legacy are robust and efficient (Spears, 2004).

Moreover, another researcher, Spears (2004) contended that the terms servant and leader are opposite to each other in their nomological network. On the other hand, it is believed and seen that people have service-orientation and supportive behaviour or attitude, bring out sound potential and growth from others.

In continuation with the above arguments about the usefulness of servant leadership, in their study on the contemporary human resource roles in the Malaysian context, Brohi et al., (2017) stated that manager play role of employee champion which means managers work for the betterment and well-being of employees. The manager acts as a leader to get the job done by his subordinates. Thus, by relating the role of manager with that of leadership, a leader in its position as a manager while leading the group of employees working under his supervision is expected to play the role of employee champion to enhance employees' well-being (Brohi, Abdullah, et al., 2018; Shah, Ali, Dahri, Brohi, & Maher, 2018), which is in line with the core concept of servant leadership, i.e. to serve followers and work for their overall well-being.

However, despite early intuitive insights on ethical implications of servant leadership in the workplace, little attention has been given to servant leadership by organisational scholars. In the last decade, researchers came up with several measures of various characteristics of servant leadership (Barbuto & Wheeler, 2006; Liden, Wayne, Zhao, & Henderson, 2008; Reed, Vidaver-Cohen, & Colwell, 2011; van Dierendonck & Nuijten, 2011). However, Liden, Wayne, Zhao, and Henderson, (2008), measure of the seven characteristics of servant leadership (i.e., empowering supervisees, creating value for community, having conceptual skills, putting supervisees first, helping supervisees grow and succeed, behaving ethically, and emotional healing) has been the most popular measure of servant leadership (Chiniara & Bentein, 2016). However, recently, Liden et al., (2015) call for validation of the short version of SL-28 stresses the need to validate the SL-

7 version in a different context and with different organisational settings. Therefore, this study proposes to use the (Liden et al., 2015) short version servant leadership scale to investigate how servant leadership influences Employees' intention to quit.

## Intention to quit

Despite the fact that colossal work has been done to come up with the measures to reduce turnover in the organisation (Hom et al., 2017), but the issue still exists. The intention to quit as a leading challenge for fortune 500 CEOs needs more examination to understand why people leave organisations (SHRM, 2016). Intention to quit means when individual thinks of leaving the organisation or quit his job shortly. This intention develops over the period in response to the adverse events he/ she faced in the workplace (Porter, Steers, Mowday, & Boulian, 1974).

Since last century, several studies have determined the behavioural objectives of employees (such as their intention to look for new job, intention to stay, intention to leave or actual turnover) to know about employee turnover (Griffeth, Hom, & Gaertner, 2000; Steel & Ovalle, 1984). Moreover, expanding on turnover literature and differentiating the overlapping concepts of intention to stay and intention to quit, in this regard, Akhtar, Salleh, and Mehmood, (2017) in their study argued that, traditionally intention to stay and intention to leave are used interchangeably, but these two concepts are distinct in nature which answers two different things. Thus, building on that claim, in this conceptual study the focus will be on intention to quit construct. Moreover, literature review and meta-analysis conducted on employee's turnover reveal that intention to leave is dependable components which are to be included in the turnover process model as indicated in the studies of Cotton and Tuttle, (1986). In result, convinced with this view, in this study, we proposed employee intention to quit as a dependent variable with servant leadership, and PsyCap is persuading it (intention to quit).

The extensive review of the literature and meta-analysis on intention to quit (Griffeth et al., 2000) showed that the employees develop intention of leaving a specific organisation if they are dissatisfied with the job. In result, this dissatisfaction with the job persuades the employee to look for a new opportunity, considering offers from new organisations and at last leave the organisation. The dissatisfaction with the job might be the result of organisational displeasure process faced by the employee (Miskel, Fevurly, & Stewart, 1979), further organisational policies (Kossek & Ozeki, 1998), or leadership style (Fuller, Morrison, Jones, Bridger, & Brown, 1999), or job characteristics (Loher, Noe, Moeller, & Fitzgerald, 1985) organisational culture (Ahmed, Khuwaja, Brohi, & Othman, 2018). The previous studies (Hunter et al., 2013; Jaramillo, Grisaffe, Chonko, & Roberts, 2009b) postulate that servant leadership style in certain conditions is a crucial factor in reducing employee intention to quit. Constructing on the argument develop earlier that leadership style induces positive behaviours in employees thus increase their job satisfaction and in turn, the positive organisational behaviours and job satisfaction affect employee intention to quit. Therefore, we propose that the servant leadership decreases Employees' intention to quit.

Therefore, the authors proposed the following:

***Proposition 1:*** *Servant leadership style is negatively associated with employees' intention to quit.*

Previous studies on the relationship of servant leadership and intention to quit have found that servant leadership is negatively related with employees' intention to quit

(Deconinck & Deconinck, 2017; Hunter et al., 2013; Jaramillo, Grisaffe, Chonko, & Roberts, 2009a; Kashyap & Rangnekar, 2016; Rodriguez, 2016). However, less is known about how this relationship works; whether this is a direct relationship or indirect relationship. If it is an indirect relationship, then what are the intervening psychological processes through which servant leadership leads to decreased intention to quit? To answer this question, the authors proposed PsyCap (Luthans, Luthans, & Luthans, 2004; Luthans, 2002; Luthans, Avolio, Walumbwa, & Li, 2005; Fred Luthans & Youssef-Morgan, 2017) as the intervening psychological mechanism through which servant leadership influences intention to quit.

## Psychological Capital

The leadership style with a people-centric approach leads towards the development of positive psychological organisational behaviour in employees (Walumbwa, Hartnell, & Oke, 2010). Accordingly, servant leadership as a people-centric leadership style proposed as a leadership style that emphasis on the development and growth of followers. In result, it seems to follow that servant leadership contributes to the positive organisational behaviour of followers.

Building upon the argument developed above that servant leadership induces positive organisational behaviors which results in positive psychological well-being among the followers, Liden et al., (2008) described emotional healing as an "act of showing sensitivity and a skill in helping in solving personal concerns of followers which enhances the healing process from hardship or trauma". Several studies, for instance, Barbuto, Gottfredson, and Searle, (2014); Barbuto and Wheeler, (2006); Searle and Barbuto, (2011); Walumbwa, Hartnell, and Oke, (2010), have suggested that the servant leader's act of showing concern to the personal issues of followers to foster the healing process may have a positive relationship to the development of the four components of PsyCap (hope, self-efficacy, optimism, and resilience).

In continuation, likewise, the emotional healing characteristic of servant leadership, Liden et al., (2008) described creating value for the community as a conscious, genuine concern for helping the community. It is a combination of awareness of what is happening in the surroundings and how it affects the community and how to improve the community. In this process, servant leader prepares his or her organisation to make a positive contribution to society and promotes a sense of community within the organisation. Research studies and conceptual papers (Barbuto, Gottfredson, & Searle, 2014; Barbuto & Wheeler, 2006; Searle & Barbuto, 2011; Walumbwa, Hartnell, & Oke, 2010) also have suggested that the trait of creating value for the community displayed by servant leaders may have a positive relationship with the development of PsyCap.

In addition, Liden et al., (2008) further, in regards to dimensions of servant leadership, operationally defined Empowering as an encouraging and facilitating others, especially immediate followers, in identifying and solving problems, as well as determining when and how to complete work tasks. Although scant, preliminary research studies and conceptual papers (e.g., Barbuto, Gottfredson, & Searle, 2014; Barbuto & Wheeler, 2006; Searle & Barbuto, 2011; Walumbwa, Hartnell, & Oke, 2010) have suggested that this ability of servant leaders to encourage and facilitate followers in problem-solving process may have a positive relationship to the development of PsyCap.

Liden et al., (2008) operationally defined conceptual skills as a skill to have the knowledge of the organisation and tasks at hand to be able to support and assist others, especially immediate followers effectively. Research studies and conceptual papers (e.g., ,

Barbuto, Gottfredson, & Searle, 2014; Barbuto & Wheeler, 2006; Searle & Barbuto, 2011; Walumbwa, Hartnell, & Oke, 2010) also have suggested that the trait of conceptual skills displayed by servant leaders may have a positive relationship with the development of PsyCap.

Liden et al., (2008) operationally defined helping subordinates grow and succeed as a deep-rooted desire to make a positive difference in followers or subordinates lives. Moreover, putting subordinates first was defined as the actions and words to communicate with followers that fulfilling their (followers) need is a top priority for the leader. Research studies and conceptual papers (e.g., Barbuto et al, 2014; Barbuto & Wheeler, 2006; Searle & Barbuto, 2011; Walumbwa, Hartnell, & Oke, 2010) suggested a positive relationship between helping subordinates grow and succeed and putting subordinates first and the development of the PsyCap.

Liden et al., (2008) operationally defined behaving ethically as a characteristic of interacting openly, fairly and honestly with others, i.e. followers, community members and with top management as well. Behaving ethically is a deep-rooted moral character of servant leader which make him different from others, thus impacts positively on the follower's attitude and behaviour. Research studies and conceptual papers (e.g., Barbuto et al, 2014; Barbuto & Wheeler, 2006; Searle & Barbuto, 2011; Walumbwa, Hartnell, & Oke, 2010) suggested a positive relationship between behaving ethically and the development of the PsyCap.

Based on the past studies and review of the literature, servant leadership directly or indirectly may have an impact on employees PsyCap. In continuation of the argument developed above, Hope has been explained in Luthans, (2002) model as the degree to which an individual display agency (willpower) and pathways (way power) to achieve desired goals. The second positive organisational behaviour, self-efficacy was drawn from Bandura, (1997) and was operationally defined as the extent to which an individual has confidence that he or she possesses the ability to complete a task or objective successfully. As operationally defined by Luthans and Youssef-Morgan, (2017), optimism refers to the extent to which an individual (a) expects things to work out as he or she desires and (b) treats undesirable events as temporary or permanent. If the sincere desire of the servant leader leads him or her to develop self-efficacy and hope in followers, then one could imagine that it would not be much of a stretch to suggest that that same deep desire of the servant leader could help instil a more profound sense of optimism among followers. Luthans and Youssef-Morgan, (2017) defined resilience as an individual's ability to bounce back in the face of adversity, hardship, or unexpected and extreme success.

Searle and Barbuto, (2011) argued that servant leaders possess a desire which is deep-rooted in leaders to meet the needs of followers and help them achieve their aspirations and goals (Liden et al., 2008). Servant leaders possess the capacity to serve their followers in such a way that they would seek to enhance hope, self-efficacy optimism and resilience, notably if these constructs are lacking in their followers (Cerff & Winston, 2006).

If a servant leader's displayed desire to care for the well-being of followers motivates those followers to have confidence in the face of uncertainty and obstacles, then it is proposed that the servant leader's perceived display of caring for others and serving nature relates positively to followers' self-rating of the four components of the PsyCap. Thus, following has been proposed:

***Proposition 2:*** *There is a positive relationship between Servant Leadership and PsyCap.*

Once employees PsyCap is fostered by their servant leadership, employees strive to be themselves, showing their true selves without even thinking about the negative consequences associated with their character or job. Thus, employees display positive behaviours of behaving ethically, being engaged, being committed and in turn, it increases performance which leads towards job satisfaction and reduced intention to quit. E*mployee retention is becoming more important nowadays than ever before because of ever-changing trends, in particular, the paradigm shift of power relationship from employer to employees (Brohi, Jantan, et al., 2018; Dries, 2013). The factors contributing to employee retention and reducing intention to quit of employees are of utmost importance. Employees who are satisfied, committed, feeling engaged in the workplace are most likely to stay with the organisation thus results in increased overall organisational performance. Therefore, building upon the preceding arguments, the following is proposed:*

***Proposition 3:*** *PsyCap will be negatively related to intention to quit.*

## The mediating role of Psychological Capital

Following the relationships proposed in Proposition 1, Proposition 2, and Proposition 3, it is rational and prompt thus we suggest PsyCap as the intervening psychological mechanism through which servant leadership influences employees' intention to quit. Building upon social exchange theory (Homans, 1958), it can be assumed that servant leadership enables the development of employees' PsyCap through behaving ethically, empowering, and putting subordinates first and in exchange employees' will reciprocate the servant leader behavior by engaging in the activities which lead towards job satisfaction, high performance and ultimately in decreased intention to quit. Building upon above arguments, the following hypothesis has been proposed:

***Proposition 4:*** *Employees' perception of PsyCap will mediate the relationship between servant leadership and Employees' intention to quit.*

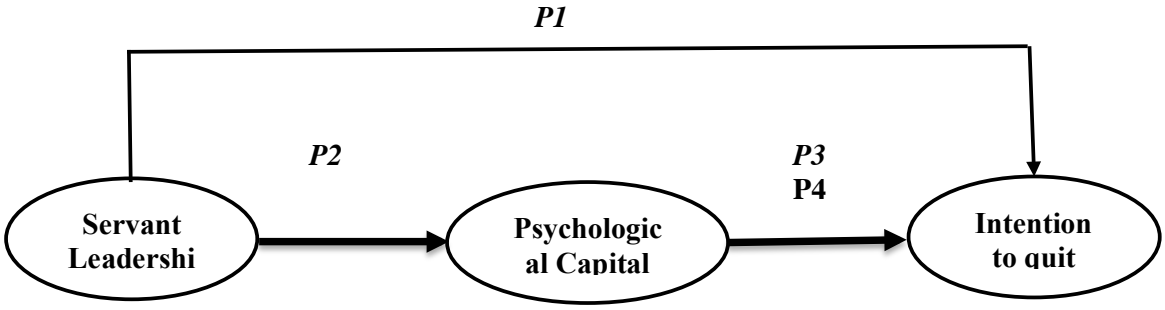


**Figure 1: Conceptual model linking Servant Leadership, PsyCap and Intention to quit**

## Future Research Directions

In this conceptual study, the authors provided some substantial directions for future pursuance aiming to build upon and unveil more new dimensions of servant leadership. In recent years, taken together, the research and advancement in the development of and validation of measurements intended to measure constructs like servant leadership and PsyCap have developed rapidly. However, despite this growing research, more research is

still required to investigate these constructs, the authors' viewpoint that both servant leadership and PsyCap constructs are well defined within positive organisational psychology and well established to be applied in management research. To investigate the proposed relationships, researchers can apply second generation statistical tools like structural equation modelling using AMOS or Smart-PLS. A cross-sectional study is recommended to understand the impact of studied variables on employees' attitude and behaviour. However, to understand more and to get in-depth knowledge about the variables, longitudinal study is also preferred. From this conceptual study, it is hoped that it would epitomise an advanced and theoretically significant development in organisational studies to examine the impact of servant leadership and PsyCap on employee behaviour, i.e. Intention to quit.

## Conclusion

Based on the arguments developed in the earlier sections and the future directions of servant leadership and PsyCap - a form of positive organisational behaviour establishes the significance and relevance of the chosen topic. In this conceptual study, we have made significant progress in understanding the factors that predict lower Intention to quit among employees and how the servant leadership behaviour induces positive attitude and behaviour among employees. Furthermore, we proposed the underlying process through which servant leadership buffers adverse outcomes, however, there is much yet to be learned. Therefore, the propositions made in this study will provide a base for the researchers to further the scholarship on servant leadership and positive organisational behaviour literature. By empirically testing the proposed relationships, researchers can draw useful conclusions which may be beneficial for organisations and enable them to take steps to develop and nurture servant leaders and help organisations to retain the best breed of employees to remain competitive in the business world.

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